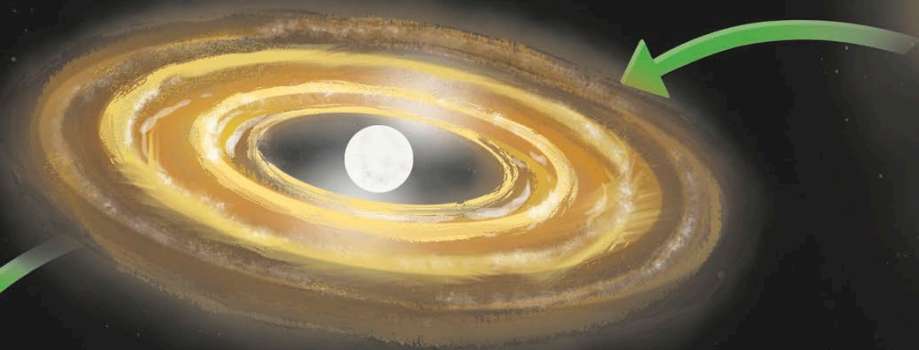


The sun is born

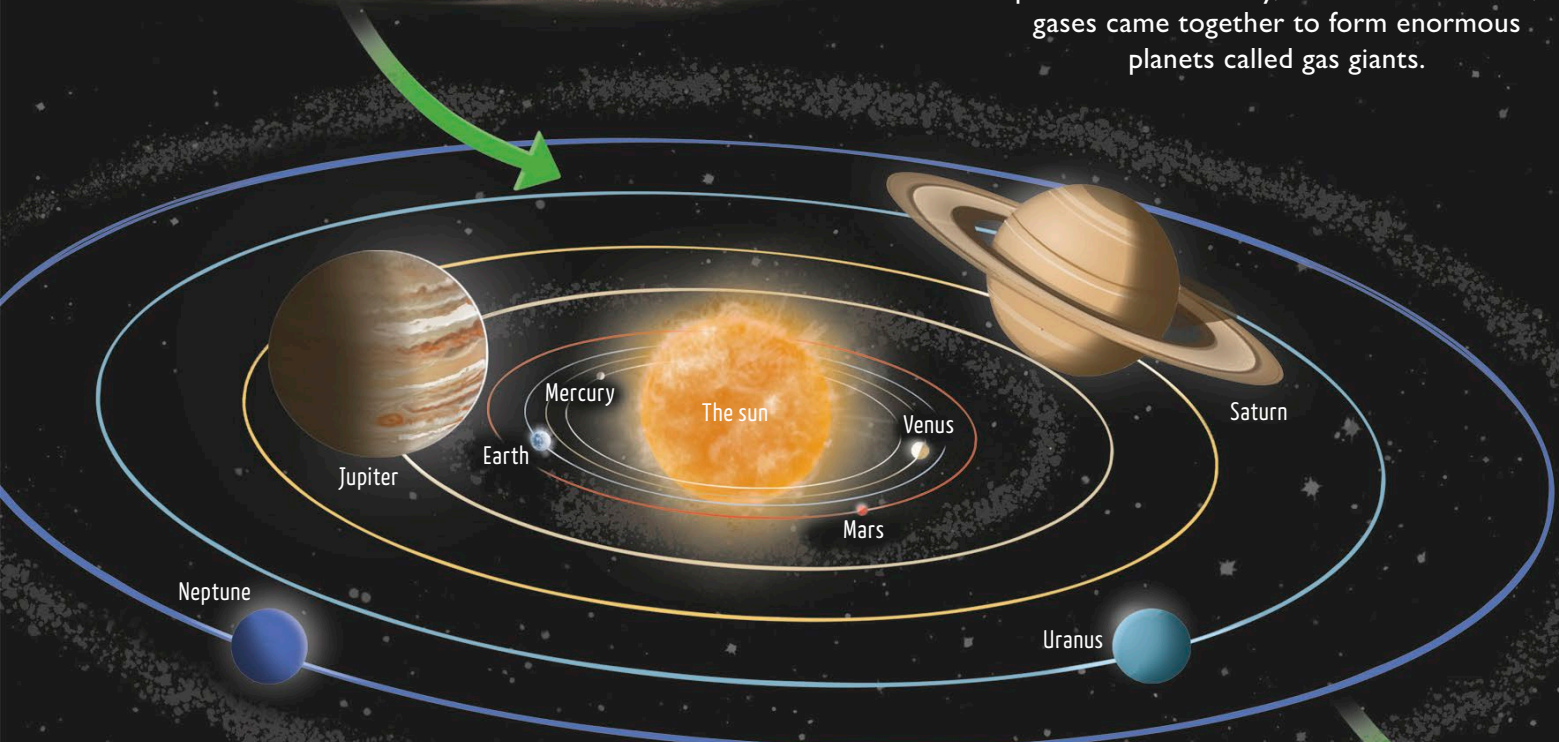
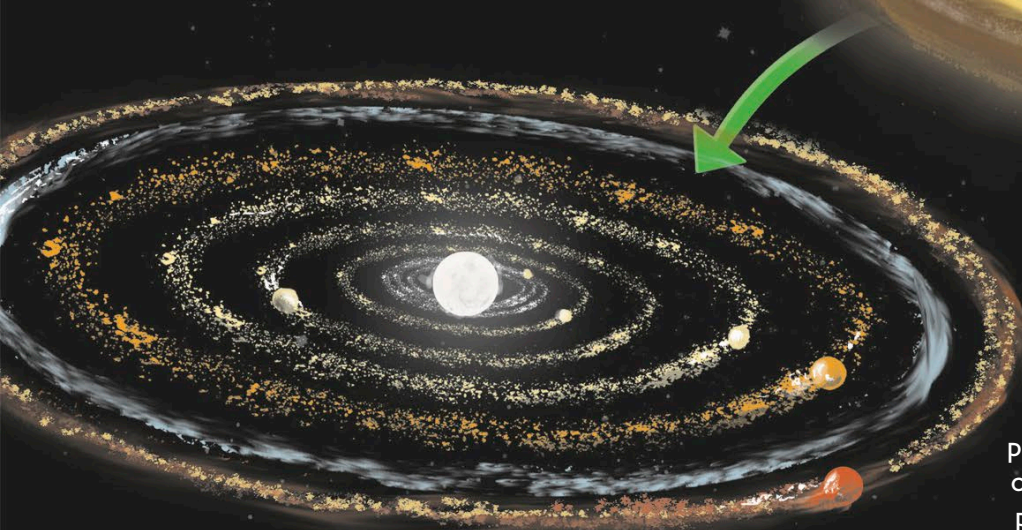
As the cloud collapsed due to gravity, its center started to heat up. It eventually became so hot that hydrogen atoms combined to make helium, in a process called fusion. This released a huge amount of energy, and a hot, shining star was born—the sun.



Some of the lightest gases spun out to the cold outer edge of the disk.

Planets forming

Material from the cloud began to form planets. Close to the sun, gravity pulled bits of dust together into clumps to form rocky planets. Farther away, where it was cooler, gases came together to form enormous planets called gas giants.



Our solar system

It took tens of millions of years for the planets to form our solar system. Mercury, Venus, Earth, and Mars are rocky planets, and Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, and Neptune are gas giants. Between Mars and Jupiter is an area called the asteroid belt. This contains many smaller dwarf planets, as well as small rocky asteroids.

Beyond Neptune's orbit, the frozen gases formed comets.

See also

Find out more about our universe (10–11) and how stars form (12–13).